

Figure 1: Hardinfo Benchmark

blend between a hardware listing and a decent benchmarking tool.

Hardinfo [<http://hardinfo.berlios.de/HomePage>] delivers precise details about the hardware installed and the connected devices atop an easy-to-use GUI. The website claims that the tool "...can gather information about your system's hardware and operating system, perform benchmarks, and generate printable reports either in HTML or in plain text formats."

The app's interface is segregated into two columns. The left column serves as the navigation bar that consists of a plethora of hardware categories, which are further divided into relevant entries. The section on the right side is the overview panel that displays some information about the entries you select from the navigation panel. When you select an entry, a new panel is created to show detailed information about the selected item.

Apart from its hardware listing capabilities, Hardinfo provides a handful of benchmarking tests to put your system through rigorous exercises. The default installation doesn't come with much data on the benchmarking front to compare your system with other hardware. However, you can easily sync with the online database (click **Information** → **Network Updater**). Updating the database adds the data of the computers that have been tested.

Sharing data online and then syncing the software is really a great idea and lets you easily compare

your system's potential with others. I advise you to sync the system with the online service, once. This not only increases the size of the hardware database, but is beneficial for others as well. Hardinfo also provides a Report Generator. This handy plug-in allows you to generate system information along with benchmarking results, either in HTML or plain text format.

This information about the system will provide a verbose report covering the X server, the Linux distribution, hot-swappable devices, network information and lots more. It even displays the temperature using the system diode; however, I found that to be faulty—my motherboard LED indicator displayed a significantly lower temperature than that of Hardinfo.

Nevertheless, there are still many things missing from the elusive Hardinfo. Shortcomings include the missing voltage meter, dynamic speed reader, and many more. A dearth of these components is surely a big setback for any hardware listing tool,

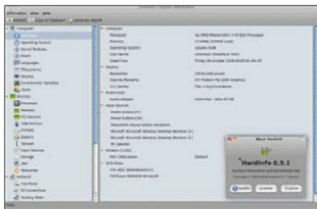


Figure 2: Hardinfo Default Looks

and without these tools one cannot make proper judgements while overclocking.

The Phoronix Test Suite

Phoronix Media, one of the most popular and reliable sources for Linux news and reviews, presented the first benchmarking test suite—the Phoronix Test Suite (PTS). Phoronix regularly publishes hardware/Linux benchmarking reviews using PTS, which throw some light on what PTS is capable of doing. Initially restricted to the CLI, PTS goes through massive transitions from release to release. It has now jumped onto the GUI bandwagon, loaded with an easy-to-use GUI. It comes with support for almost all distributions and is available in the repositories of many distributions.

Id say Phoronix takes benchmarking to a whole new level, being the only one of its kind that provides users the option of 'live benchmarking' (thanks to the availability of an Ubuntu-based live

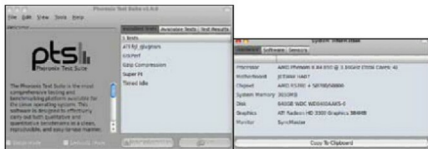


Figure 3: PTS System Overview